

Words and Word-Bodies

Writing the Religious Body

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Cartesian Transgressions

When theorizing historical understandings of the body in religious contexts, we see familiar and related images of the body: the religious body as martyred body, the religious body as submissive body, the religious body as that which must be veiled. When one contemplates all the things done to the body, done *for* the body, from fasting to ascetic mortification to hook piercings to motionless sitting to veils to habits, all in the quest of religion, it is hard not to see this past as a history of flight from the body, even as the body is the very mechanism for this flight.

Much of this imagery of the religious body is founded on an axiomatic dualism separating spirit and body as two poles of an antithesis that ultimately favors only one of these poles. Apart from the social and political effects of this dualism, it would be not unfair to suggest that one key piece of the self-understanding of many if not all religious traditions has been this message: both the possibility of and the techniques for transcending that flawed, permeable, and impermanent lump of matter we call the body.

We might add that the turn away from religion heralded by the humanism of the Enlightenment and modernity did little to undo the dominant model that privileges the transcendence of the body, with its intrinsic antithesis of body and spirit. Instead, the Cartesian split between mind and body reinvested this split with a scientific authority. It embedded this antithesis in the very heart of our modern understanding of rationality. Rethinking the religious body, then, requires a shift of this central metaphor in mapping the body's place in relation to spirit.



Of course, religion has not been only about escaping the body. The point of the Christian concept of the resurrection is precisely the preservation of the body, in its physical, most corporeal sense, even as this notion necessarily arises out of the overwhelming impulse to flee the body. And yet the very point of the resurrection is that it only happens once; the new body that will rise on Judgment Day will not have to be exchanged or made whole again. It is a body one can keep, a body guaranteed to be free from the body's customary pains and permeability, susceptibility to disease, and uncontrollable desires. It is the antithesis of what *we* know as body.

Similarly, one can consider as a counter to the religious desire to flee the body the idea of incarnation, which emerges in a variety of religious traditions. In Christianity, for instance, Jesus is the Word made flesh. One can read this message of Christianity, understood as God incarnating (which is radical, I think, in light of its Jewish roots), in psychological terms so as to turn the flight from the body into an embrace of bodies. Yet here as well, theologically Jesus dies a rather brutal death precisely so that we do not have to—though only in our essence, only metaphorically, not in our bodies. Christians still are subject to bodily death, even as we all are. The divine body of Christ is mutilated precisely so that the *spirit* in all these other bodies can be free. Indeed one can read the incarnation as conveying precisely the opposite import: a displacement of the sufferings of *spirit*, of souls condemned in the afterlife, by the idea that God acts in a body to reconcile the terrible fate of mortality that hounds this human condition of being embodied.

Yet this Christian conceptualization alerts us to something essential in the formulation of the relationship between body and spirit. The idea of spirit is inflected in a particular way where language—the Word, *logos*—becomes the marker for spirit. Indeed, a number of contemporary thinkers—including especially Judith Butler, but also others, from Jacques Lacan to Jacques Derrida, have articulated this Cartesian binary as founded particularly on language. In a series of influential studies, Butler has focused on this marker of language as the fundamental mooring for identity, as that which shapes the very life of the body.¹ The articulation of this binary and the deconstruction of the political and social givens it implicates have spawned an intellectual industry, one that seeks to unravel the political agendas imbricated in the ways language constrains, defines, and even boldly creates the body.²

In this essay, I will not address this discourse or attempt to nuance this theme. I mention it to highlight its obverse, which has largely been neglected: I want to explore how language itself might be understood to be constrained, even created by the idea of the body. In other words, what if we were to try to think the resolution of the problem of the body from the other end? What if we rethink the Word? What if word itself might be understood as always already flesh? What if the word in its essence never was anything other than body?

I focus on a specific example, that of *nyāsa*, a Tantric practice that transforms the human body into a divine body by ritually inserting magical words, by writing language



on the body. I will suggest that this practice of writing the body allows us to rethink the religious body from the other side of the equation—that is, by allowing us to rethink what language is and how it functions in relation to the idea of body. The cosmology implicated in this practice not only provides a new understanding of body (i.e., body made divine), it also affords an even more daring philosophical transgression—a corporealizing of spirit. This practice rearticulates the essence of language to configure it as a body, doing what bodies do. In other words, here the model of *body* infuses what *language* is—in its deepest core, as its essence.

Tantra as a practice is infamous for transgressions against social norms. I will suggest that the transgressions that Tantra proposes are so potent at least in part because they are philosophical and cosmological transgressions. They run counter to the way we think and the way we order the universe. I will propose that the transgression Tantra enacts works to undo the Cartesian chasm, the ubiquitous binary opposition between body and spirit: It works by reconfiguring language itself in its most powerful essence as a body.

I have argued elsewhere that some forms of Tantric practice operate precisely to refuse the Cartesian paradigm, the hierarchical split between body and spirit, which turns out also to be a prevalent model in much Indian philosophical thought.³ That is, in some instances, the heart of the transgression that the sex rite presents is a reversal of the terms body and spirit. So we see the God Śiva revealing the secret of the sex rite by saying, “O Goddess I am the body [*deha*] and you are the spirit within the body [*dehin*],”⁴ reversing the standard trope of female as body and male as spirit. In this context, as I have argued, rewriting cosmology is the real secret, the transgression; sex merely operates to distract from this deeper philosophical move.

The case of *nyāsa* also rewrites cosmology by rewriting the Cartesian binary, fusing the very categories *body* and *word*. In what follows, I will first discuss *nyāsa*, inserting language on the body in its general instance and in a particular case that also involves actually writing with sandalwood paste on a woman’s body. I will thereby show that the Tantric practice of *nyāsa* offers a cosmological articulation of language that understands language first and foremost as a body. Language in this context is performative; it is a body. The practice of *nyāsa* transforms the physical body by fusing these two bodies, the word-body and the body made of matter. After discussing the practice of *nyāsa*, I will briefly relate this conception of language to the idea of an alternate, performative language in the West as the language of the dream, nonsense, the gibberish of the mental patient. By way of conclusion, I will suggest that we ought to pay attention to this Tantric notion of language because in fact this reconceptualization of language and the body is already taking hold in popular imagination in the West. I will suggest that popular scientific conceptions of the body look very much like a Tantric notion of the body, in the images of superhero mutants and terminators. The mutant body and the terminator body both reflect a parallel of writing the body like the one we see in the case of *nyāsa*. In these cases, like the Tantric instance of *nyāsa*, the body is written with a language that is per-



formative, not semantically driven, and then transformed by this writing into a powerful, divineline body.

Nyāsa: Language and the Body

Nyāsa is a Hindu Tantric technique that uses language to transform the ordinary body into a divine body. The practitioner ritually places words and syllables of words on the different limbs of the body. These syllables and words make up a *mantra*, a magical verbal formula, which through the power of these words transforms the subtle essence of the physical body into a more powerful body, indeed, a body capable of superhuman feats, *siddhis* such as flying, becoming massively heavy, controlling the elements water and fire, becoming invisible, and so on. The *mantra* used for *nyāsa* in most cases is a simple formula that includes the name of the deity one is worshipping. I will give a widespread and popular example. A well-known *mahāmantra*, that is, a “great” *mantra* or *mantra* that works even if one has not been properly initiated in it, is the *mantra* “*Om namaḥ Śivāya*” for the god Śiva. The *mantra* literally translates as “*Om*, honor to Śiva.” The first syllable, “*om*,” is a word that carries no semantic content but performatively evokes a creative subtle energy that imbues the space where it is recited with imperceptible yet potent efficacies for prosperity and spiritual potency.

In the *nyāsa* performed with this *mantra*, the practitioner recites the first syllable, “*om*,” either aloud or mentally, places the fingers of both hands on the heart, and then mentally imagines the sound being inserted into his or her heart. The practitioner recites, “*om śivāya namaḥ*,” “*om* to the heart, honor.” With this, the practitioner’s heart changes its subtle substance, becomes imbued with the inherent potency of the sound “*om*.” He or she then recites the syllable “*na*” while placing the first three fingers of both hands on the top of the head. The practitioner recites, “*na śirase swāhā*,” “*na* the offering to the top of the head.” Again, the practitioner imagines the subtle essence of the first part of this word, *namaḥ*, meaning to honor, to enter into the head and transform it via the subtle power of the word. The word “*swāhā*,” like “*om*,” is used ritually at the end of an offering into a sacrificial fire, but it does not carry semantic meaning. Next the practitioner places the back of the fists with thumbs outstretched to the back of the head and completes the word with the syllable “*maḥ*,” with the same mental insertion of the word and its subtle energy into the back of the head. With this, the practitioner recites, “*maḥ śikhayai vaṣat*,” “*maḥ* to the crest of the back of the head, *vaṣat*.” Again, *vaṣat* is a word that is used ritually and that does not carry semantic meaning. Then the practitioner crosses the arms across the torso, placing each hand on the opposite arm, reciting the first syllable of the name Śiva, “*śi kavacāya huṃ*,” “*śi* to the protective armor, *huṃ*.” He or she then touches the eyes with the next syllable, “*vā*,” and completes the word *Śivāya* with its final syllable, “*ya*,” while rolling the palms on top of one another



ritually to create an *astra*, a subtle weapon for protecting this newly imbued divine body.

With this, the original *mantra* is atomically broken down into its syllabic components, and each of the syllables is inserted on a different part of the body. In this way the whole mantra, which is normally spoken and thus temporally located, becomes spatially located, mapped onto the physical body.

There are a number of variations on this technique, including *nyāsa*s that involve placing *mantras* on the feet, the sex organ, and the thighs, others that include the stomach, the sex organ, and the *ajñā cakra*, which is the place of the third eye in the forehead, and the base of the spine. Moreover, in most cases, *nyāsa* is also performed on the hands as an initial supplement to the performance of *nyāsa* on the body. In a *nyāsa* taken from the Śrī Vidyā tradition, one mentally imagines offering substances such as incense, a flame lamp, flowers—standard items offered in a *pūjā*, a worship ceremony, to the deity residing in the various parts of the body, including the base of the spine, the throat, the heart, the stomach, and the sexual organ. For this, one recites a *mantra* in Sanskrit that notes the substance offered, for instance, “*Om ram vahnitattvātmikāyai Lalitāmbikāyai dīpaṃ parikalpayāmi*” “*Om ram* to the goddess Lalitā, who is the essence of the element of fire I offer a lamp.” Here the syllable “*ram*” is an esoteric encoding of the body part, the stomach, signified by the syllable “*ram*’s” association with the energy center called the “jewel” (*maṇi cakra*), located in the stomach. One can ascertain this esoteric association by cross-referencing textual sources; however, it is usually passed down as part of an oral tradition.

Nyāsa is so common that often ritual texts do not describe how to perform *nyāsa*, but simply tell the practitioner to do it. Thus we find in the *Bṛhannīla Tantra*, when the Goddess asks for a secret rite related to awakening the energy at the base of the spine, the God Bhairava responds with a mere stipulation that *nyāsa* first be performed, after which he explains the rest of the rite. We see, “Bhairava said: After having thoroughly performed the *mantra nyāsa*, he performs the *ṛṣi nyāsa*, etc. First, having given a seat, he should worship the highest deity.”⁵ Details of the rite and its results follow. In this case, the author of the text assumes the reader already knows how to do the *nyāsa* and promptly proceeds to detail the rest of the rite. Likewise, in the text of the three hundred names of Lalitā, the *Lalitā Trīṣati*, an important text for the Śrī Vidyā tradition, after the opening verses and a detailed statement of intention for the ritual recitation known as the *saṅkalpa*, a mere textual nod, not even a complete sentence, indicates that following this the practitioner should do the *nyāsa*. “With the root [syllables], the *nyāsa* of the six limbs.”⁶ The six limbs here are the heart, the top of the head, the back of the head, the two arms, the eyes, and the palms of the hands.

As part of the basic ritual template, *nyāsa* is incorporated as an essential element of nearly every Tantric ritual. Tantric praxis is multiple, with a wide variety of deities, a wide range of practices, and a multiplicity of motives for the practices undertaken, yet *nyāsa* is performed across the board, regardless of the deity and the lineage of the practice.



Why is *nyāsa* so essential to the Tantric ritual?—that is, what exactly does *nyāsa* do? I have pointed out that the practitioner understands *nyāsa* as a means of transforming the ordinary body into a more powerful, divine body. The subtext is that language is the link to the divine. The gods, like humans, have bodies, but their bodies are different from our physical bodies because they are fundamentally bodies made of language. Thus we see in a popular hymn to the Goddess Lakṣmī, “O Goddess, whose body is always the *mantra*, honor to you O Great Lakṣmī.”⁷ By a kind of contagion, in the practice of *nyāsa* one’s own body modulates itself to the higher body of the deity, whose body is made of language. Abhinavagupta, an eleventh-century Tantric philosopher, articulates how this idea operates philosophically. He says:

“This-ness” [the state of being an object rather than subject] in fact is predominant in the physical body, in the intellect and in the vital air, and so on. These [the physical body and so on] are not at all like the form which a word [*śabda*]⁸ takes when it is perceived. The [physical body and so on] cause consciousness to contract, become limited; they cover and obscure consciousness very tightly indeed! In this way the body that language takes—and this is what *mantra* is—this language-body continually reverberates in the sky of the heart as the form of pure awareness, with its innate capacity to act as active awareness [*vimarśa*]. For this reason *mantra* is called the unstruck sound constantly arising.⁹

Thus, language takes a kind of body, but a kind of body different from the physical body. The physical body causes our awareness to contract. Moreover, in Abhinava’s scheme, even the intellect and the breath operate to limit our awareness. One might expect the opposite with the intellect, since in our worldview it stands akin to the transcendent life of the mind. Yet in Abhinavagupta’s system it functions in the same way as do bones and flesh—to contract consciousness. In contrast, the body that language takes is a sound continually echoing in the heart. This language is pure awareness, *vimarśa*, which for Abhinava’s system is one of two forms of the highest reality of the cosmos.

Language offers a special facility in this movement toward greater freedom and awareness. The body that language takes generates awareness. The practice of *nyāsa* then, by merging the physical body with the language body of *mantra*, causes the physical to become lightened, we may say “enlightened,” less burdened by its weight as object and more closely aligned with the freedom and awareness of subject that the *vimarśa* entails.

Again Abhinavagupta tells us:

“*Vācakaḥ*” is “the Word, i.e., what signifies,”¹⁰ this “Word” is the heart of supreme awareness, deliberate awareness, but not only in particular words which are heard [and spoken]. Rather it also pertains to the Word which is more profound than *Māyā*,



the phenomenal world, which does not belong to *Māyā*, but instead enlivens and makes the phonemes which exist on the level of *Māyā* alive.¹¹

Language exists both on the level of the word that is spoken and as a subtle reality that gives life to language as phoneme, as word on the phenomenal level of existence. Language lies at the very heart of awareness, and words have a power beyond the life of the body. It is this idea of language, the Word, that causes the words that one hears spoken to have life. Indeed, language operates performatively.

In the cosmology of this Tantric system, life is bound up on a great chain of being. One's place within this great chain depends upon the mode of one's perspective. There are in this cosmological blueprint two modes; everything exists on a continuum between them. These two modes are the place of the subject, on one end of the spectrum, and the place of the object, on the other. It is no accident that these two fundamental perspectives derive from a linguistic appreciation of phenomena.

The subjective and the objective each divide into three "pathways," *adhvans*." The pathways of subjectivity divide into letters (*varṇa*), *mantras*, and words (*pāda*), while the three pathways of objectivity divide into *kalā*, the smallest elements of the material world, *tattva*, archetypes of the cosmos, and *bhuvana*, the various worlds. In other words, the pole of subjectivity is understood fundamentally to be language. The letters (*varṇa*), being the atomic particles of language (*śabda*), represent subjectivity at its most primordial, most powerful, and most inarticulate. Cosmologically the world expands first out of letters. Following out of them secondarily in the expansion (*prapañca*) of subjective being come *mantras*, magical performative language, and then finally words (*pāda*). The *varṇas* do not indicate meaning. Rather, they indicate essence, the essence of being and subjectivity. As the most subtle form they are also the most powerful.¹²

In contrast to the pole of language and subject, the more one identifies with the idea of object, the less powerful, more bound one becomes. The object is a thing, the "it" as opposed to the "I," which is the subject. By moving to the pole of subjectivity, one moves toward divinity and the greater freedom, awareness, and power that it brings. This cosmological great chain of being moves through objects from gross matter—stones and clay—through plant and animal life and up higher on the scale into human life. As one moves higher up the scale, one aligns more with subjectivity; one's body becomes more subtle and powerful. Higher than the human are those beings, *mantrēśvaras* and *vidyeśvaras*, whose bodies consist of *mantra*, powerful magical language.

On the lower levels, purely physical matter occurs in the hierarchy of the five elements: earth, water, fire, air, and space. These five have five more subtle analogues: odor, taste, form, feeling, and sound. Sound here occupies a curious position, since it functions as both a material phenomenon in physical sound and as language, words. The Sanskrit word *śabda*, which Abhinavagupta uses, incorporates both these meanings. Language as sound naturally forms a bridge from gross body to the subtle world. Abhinavagupta explains this.¹³





That [*vācakaḥ*, Word] is the Self, and partakes of I-consciousness. The beings who exist as rulers of words [*vidyeśvaras*] become limited because of the mutual interaction of the word-body and the class of objects. Language and sound [*śabda*] have limitless light because they lack a dense covering over them [unlike form, taste, touch etc.]. . . . Thus, this [language] is the Subject and so on, wrapped around and made limited and precise by a particular handle as particular word [*graha*- not *śabda* here] and by a particular material basis [the actual object].¹⁴

This quote takes us into an aspect of cosmology that I do not have the space to address in depth here: namely, that in Abhinava's system beings who, like gods, are higher than humans have bodies that are made of words. We saw this briefly above in the quote from the hymn to the Goddess Lakṣmī, whose body is the *mantra*. This, of course, is radically different from our own view of language. In this system, words and sound are akin to the realm of the physical, insofar as they also consist of bodies, literally word-bodies (*śabdaśarīratva*). A word-body is less dense than a body made of bones and blood. Language exists as limitless light, yet language can also be wrapped around by materiality and a particular word—here, literally, something that grasps it (*graha*).

What this entails is a continuity of body and language. In Abhinava's monistic Tantric view, matter at base is fundamentally not different from pure consciousness. Language is an especially subtle, less dense form of the elements, and as such it acts as a kind of alchemical rod, transforming the human physical body into the subtle sound body of the deity. Body and language, rather than being polar antipodes, are obverse sides of each other. Language is in fact simply a subtle transformation of the physical materiality of human bodies.

We see *nyāsa* everywhere performed in Tantra precisely because it taps into the morphability of bodies—into a body's capacity to move up the chain from the space of body as physical object to a body of words, functioning in the mode of subject rather than object. Language is a body, and it is body extended to its most refined condition.

The cosmology in which *nyāsa* figures offers a kind of literal twist on some contemporary ideas of self as constructed by language, such as Judith Butler's, in which the self is interpolated and constructed by the linguistic world, with its limiting parameters into which we are born and socialized. That is, one can read this cosmology as subscribing to a deconstructivist notion of identity, whose very possibilities are determined by the language we have available to talk of them. It does so, however, in a very literal and profound way, a way that extends the very idea of language to language as bodied—even as it retains as language's most superficial level our Western models of language as conceptual and semantic. Thus, when performing *nyāsa*, the practitioner not only acknowledges that our identities are constructed by the parameters of the language we inherit, he or she actively works to construct identity out of language. Here, however, the most effective way to construct an identity, to build a body out of language, is to use the more powerful form of

language that is *mantra*, performative language, rather than *pāda*, language as semantic concept.

This brings us to a telling element of *nyāsa* that deserves close attention. *Nyāsa* breaks up the *mantra*, without regard for its semantic content. When the practitioner inserts the words onto the body, the words are split apart and dispersed over the various limbs. In the example given, the sentence “*om namaḥ Śivāya*” has a meaning, “honor to Śiva,” yet the meaningful units—the words in the sentence—are not kept intact. They are, rather, free-floating, meaningless syllables, “*na*” on the top of the head, “*śi*” on the arms, and so on. The physical mapping of these phonemes proposes a notion of language divorced from its semantic function. Rather than meaning-bearing components, the phonemes are treated iconically, the sonic form as itself full of power, a deity. The “*śi*” phonemes function as bodies themselves.

Indeed, elsewhere we find that *mantras* are treated in just this way, not as meaning-bearing sentences or even names, but rather more like bodies. In a discussion of how the practitioner might remedy the effects of his laziness or delusions that might arise along the Tantric path, the *Bṛhannīla Tantra* offers a number of procedures designed to restore the strength (*vīrya*) of the practitioner’s *mantra*.¹⁵ The text enjoins, for instance: “by separating the consonants from the vowels, that is called ‘causing life’ [*jīvanam*] for that [*mantra*].”¹⁶ Similarly, we find, “having written all together the letters of the *mantra*, he should strike each letter one by one with sandalwood water [reciting] the syllable of the wind, *yam*. That is called striking it.”¹⁷ Interestingly, here, the word for striking (*tādanam*) is the same word that this text uses to denote the act of sex. In another example, we see, “he should sprinkle each individual letter of the *mantra* with the water of the *kuśa* plant, saying mentally the *mantra*. This procedure is known as ‘nourishing’ [*āpyāyana*].”¹⁸

Each of these procedures treats this language as a body—to be hit, made love to, nourished, or sprinkled with water. This especially powerful language, the magical language of the *mantra*, is not semantically driven; rather, it is itself corporeal. It does not exist in an abstracted dimension of meaning. It exists rather as bodies; one interacts physically with these words. Indeed, language in its essence and at its most powerful is not a semantic enterprise. It is not, as Saussure proposed, fundamentally a communication of meaning in which signs, the words chosen for this communication, are arbitrarily set by social, cultural conventions. Rather, the essence of language is a subtle body, a kind of matter that lacks the limitations of bodies and matter made of clay and flesh.

Moreover, the use of *mantra* in ritual context emphasizes the lack of semantic content. One receives a *mantra* through initiation and then recites that *mantra* in a practice called *japa*, over and over and over, whether ten thousand or one hundred thousand times, to an extent long past the point where semantic content might be conveyed. Like the compulsive repetition of the Freudian symptom, the *mantra* functions performatively rather than semantically. I would suggest that the repetition of the *mantra*, like the Freudian symptom, is a repetition writ large that functions via repetition to connect the body to



the word. One recites the *mantra* over and over in order to effect a kind of fusion of the physical body with the word-body that is the *mantra*. One could argue that the symptom of the neurotic operates on this template as well, to bring the repressed meaning that the patient cannot bring himself to name into the performative functioning of the body, the handwashing that is obsessively performed again and again, and so on.

I noted above that the word used for “striking” the *mantra* is the same word used to describe the act of sex. In other words, the male practitioner engages with these words in the same way as he engages with a woman in the sex rite. Elsewhere I have argued that this is not an accident. There is a homology between women and the magical language of *mantras*; moreover, women have a special facility with *mantras*. Along with this, I have argued that the *mantra* as performative speech is gendered, and that women’s speech has been understood to be performative.¹⁹ I will not rehash this here, except to note that the magical language of *mantra*—which in Tantra is generally considered more powerful than ordinary, semantically driven language—points to a quality of language that is mostly neglected in the West. This performative magical language linked to women—who are, in the history of the West and in India, linked with the body—echoes a logic of association whereby women/body/performative language stand in contrast to male/spirit/word as logical or semantically cohesive language. It makes sense that this particular type of performative language, which is already more akin to bodies, would be the lynchpin tying the physical body together with the abstract element of mind that is language. Inchoately seething through the inarticulate gestures of the body is a philosophical transgression; in this Tantric magical technology, *nyāsa* is engineered to break and bridge the boundary between word and body, spirit and flesh.

Writing the Feminine Body

One more uncannily suggestive element of the ritual inflects this association of woman/body/magical language and the body’s transformation into language by means of *nyāsa*. In a worship, or *pūjā*, involving a woman, *nyāsa* is performed with a variation in which the practitioner ritually writes the letters of the *mantra* onto the body of a woman seated on the dais, the *maṇḍala*, using red sandalwood paste.²⁰ “He should write all of these with devotion, according to the rules, with the stalk of the Acacia plant.”²¹ We find, “on her two breasts, the syllable of Ramā, on each side of her jaw, the two syllables of Bhaga. Below her armpits, O supreme Goddess, he should write the two syllables of the one who holds the Ganges river,”²² and so on. These rites are secret, illicit; they are performed in the dead of night at an abandoned house or a lonely spot in a forest. Moreover, the writer disguises the actual syllables scripted on the body in a secret code, that is, as “the one who holds the Ganges river.” The key to decode these veiled clues is handed down orally from teacher to disciple.



Now, one wonders, why write the letters on the body of the woman, rather than insert them mentally as is done in all other performances of *nyāsa*?²³ Why does a woman's body necessitate this more tangible articulation of language through writing? Apart from the ritually powerful rhetorical flourish gained in this externalized act, the implications of this gesture are multiple and profound. Is it, as Lévi-Strauss suggests, that writing carries an originary violence, where it functions as a sociological rather than an intellectual enterprise, as a tool of domination?²⁴ In this scenario, writing on the body of the woman might be read as a literalization of the hierarchy of the genders.

However, the force of Lévi-Strauss's critique is no doubt tainted by a Rousseauian nostalgia for nature, the natural in opposition to the civilized, as Derrida has pointed out.²⁵ In any case, the theme of nature in contrast to culture is also not alien to the Indian context. One can reconstruct the dilemma of nature and culture in the Brahminical rites of *saṃskāra*, the *upanāyana*, for instance, which frees the twice-born boy from the ill-favored idiocy of being without culture—even though we see that in the Brahminical context the terms are reversed. That is, in the Indian context, culture, *saṃskṛti*, perennially trumps nature, *Prakṛti*. In this case nature, *Prakṛti*, is not the sentimental figure of the lost mother; she is the treacherous feminine deceiver, the multiform of *Māyā*, whose wiles keep the sincere seeker from enlightenment. One, of course, may also read this opposition between nature and culture as a recapitulation of the opposition between body and mind, or flesh and spirit. Here we might also extend it to the dichotomy we noted earlier—women / body / performative language standing in contrast to male / spirit / word as logical or semantically cohesive language.

It is, of course, not an accident that the Tantric worldview we address here reverses this pervasive orthodox devaluation of *Māyā*. Just as we saw earlier, as Abhinava's monistic Tantra works to bridge the boundary between the body and spirit and does so via the magical language of *mantra*, so too Abhinavagupta reinvests *Māyā* in a strategic Tantric move to embrace the multiplicity and messiness of the world. Critiquing the more orthodox Vedantin and Sāṃkhya views, he tells us, "*Māyā* is in fact the form of the Energy of God."²⁶ This reversal extends to the understanding of the chain of associations that links body to woman to performative speech. *Māyā* as nature stands as the woman's body, upon which are scripted the powerful phonemes evocative in the Tantric context of the Goddess's own self-revelation as *mālinī*, the letters of the alphabet, which create the cosmos. With this, the opposition between nature and culture in effect collapses—as it must in a truly monist philosophical system. In other words, writing the letters on the body of the woman is an invocation of language and a refusal of the opposition between language and body; it refuses any notion of language as identity that transcends and opposes the presence of body. It is a concentrated, deliberate fusing of physical body with language as subtle body, fusing the two via language.

The writing on the body is not of the order of the logos, the word carving and mapping a meaning into the territory of the body. Rather, as we saw earlier, the practitioner



scripts onto the body simple, meaningless syllables, *bīja*, “seed” letters, that have no semantic content. As letters (*varṇa*), the basic constituents that make up the *mantra*, these letters reach down to a primordial, inchoate essence just beginning to blossom into life.

To script the letters, the *varṇas*, onto the body of a woman is at once a recognition of a primordial subjectivity—the pathway of letters, *varṇa adhvān*—appropriately replicated on the body of the female and also a secret sharing, a re-membering, an articulation of each limb as its subtle counterpart as word-body. That which is body and “other,” namely, object, is made into subject by the writing of letters. *Nyāsa* is a preparatory rite in seeing the woman as goddess; this writing effects the fusion of body with Goddess as *mantra*.

The Underside of Language

The writing on the body that the Tantric practice of *nyāsa* entails offers a way to rethink the relationship between language and the body by rethinking what language does *to* the body. Moreover, this rethinking of the relationship between language and the body generates and derives from a broader model of the function of language itself, namely, what it is that language does. That is, rather than constructing the body through discourse, as mere object of language, in a discourse that pits mute body against transcendent mind or spirit, spirit aligned with language, this Tantric practice hints at transforming our ideas of language instead. The word becomes akin to the body, becomes itself a body.

One of Foucault’s most productive insights was his postulation that the seventeenth century marked the birth of an epoch, a transformation in ideologies governing the body, insofar as it produced a wealth of discursive attention to the body in numerous discourses, medical treatises, and the institutions of psychiatry and pedagogy. He tells us that what marks off modernity is a profusion of writing about the body, and a new kind of writing about the body.²⁷ The writing of the body that he discusses represents the triumph of a rationality, a use of language to master its other, the corporeal, amorphous collection of pains and desires that is the body.

This profusion, however, brought in its wake attention to another kind of language in relation to the body. The advent of psychoanalysis attempted to map out this other kind of language, the underside of language, the gibberish of the patient, language as nonsense, the obscure automatic writing that Myers, Janet, and James saw as a doorway to other selves,²⁸ language as performative embodiment of the symptom and the incoherence of metaphors in dreams. Since I have elsewhere in much greater detail discussed the correspondences between the magical language of *mantra* and this other performative language, language as the symptom of the patient,²⁹ I will here only reiterate that both *mantra* and language as symptom operate primarily as performative language, as language divorced from semantic impart. The nonsensical language of the *mantra* is the



underside of language as rationality. In contrast, the Tantric view reverses the hierarchy of rational to irrational, semantic to performative that Freud assumes, instead transposing the pathology Freud imputes to it onto divinity, superior power. This language, atomically split in a destruction of its semantic element, this language as body, transforms both language and body as it fuses with body as matter. The *mantra* is semantically dismantled and the body becomes a super-body. Technical mastery over the subtle body of words gives way to the magical *siddhis*, the magical powers that Tantra offers; it enables the practitioner to attain physically a super-body.

Rethinking the religious body in such a way that reincorporates language in the body and invests the body with language and *as* language, as we see in the practice of *nyāsa*, operates as a metaphor for a psychological restructuring of the relationship between body and mind, between matter and spirit. This performative, unsemantic language that defies the rational strictures of language offers a way of rethinking the religious body; it is homologous with the body and represents a transformation of the body.

Writing the Religious Body, Writing the Mutant Body

In 2009 *Newsweek* ran an article by Lisa Miller proclaiming that Americans are conceptually and ideologically becoming Hindus.³⁰ The emphasis on a plurality of religious horizons and an increasing acceptance of reincarnation are two of the beliefs she cites as signaling this ecclesiastical sea change. Perhaps, however, it may be more apropos to suggest that in fact we may be becoming Tantrics. Specifically, our understanding of the body as it participates in cosmos and the religious construction of cosmos is transforming. As we leave the twentieth century and venture into the next millennium, one of the most striking conceptual transformations centers on the idea of the religious body. Indeed, one could argue that the dominant political challenge of our first decade, terrorism, pivots around a conflict between older and newer conceptions of the religious body.³¹ I would suggest that science, and the idea of science, have changed the way we view our cosmos. They have especially changed the way we view the human body in the cosmos, inadvertently moving us in the direction of a Tantric notion of the body.

By a Tantric notion of the body, I mean an ideology that reincorporates the body, literally. Tantric practice in general—and *nyāsa* is an instance of this—works to transform and replace the ordinary physical body with a divine, more powerful body. One other well-known practice of Tantra, though not as ubiquitous as *nyāsa*, is the practice of *bhūta śuddhi*, the purification of the elements. Like the practice of *nyāsa*, this practice also transforms the body, in this case by mentally destroying the five constituent elements of the body—earth, air, water, fire, and space, and rebuilding the body again out of these elements in a more powerful way with *mantras*. Thus, rather than a flight from the body, through the



invocation of a transcendence from the body into spirit, one might understand a Tantric perspective toward the body as one that instead reinvests and embraces the body.

As I pointed out at the outset, one could suggest that historically, within a traditional religious framework, the religious body has stood as something of an oxymoron. That is, religions have in the main sought to erase the body in favor of a transcendence of the body, particularly as a response to mortality, the fact that the body dies. By contrast, Tantric practices generally operate instead to reclaim the body through the transformation of the body into a divine body and a super-body. I would suggest that we find a similar transformation of the body creeping into contemporary popular culture via a scientific displacement of Darwin's body, as the mutant body, the body of the X-men, and more recently in the body of the cyborg. This twenty-first-century body of our popular fantasies, in fact, looks very much like a Tantric body. These mutant bodies and terminators, like the transformed Tantric body, display all sorts of *siddhis*, magical powers: the power to fly, to command the elements, to bring storms and attract iron, the power to become invisible.

What is more interesting is the mechanism constituting this new, powerful mutant body. These new bodies are being reconfigured by a code—that is to say, by a language. It is not a language that is semantically driven; rather, like the Tantric use of *mantra*, it is a performative language. In other words, I suggest that DNA is a code, a language, yet it is a performative language, not semantically driven.³² The transformation into the mutant body is a transformation that occurs through a kind of writing on the body with a primordial language, the DNA, the mystical language written deep into the cells of our bodies, fusing physical body and language. Like the *varṇas*, the letters that the Tantric uses to script the body, the code of DNA is a primordial and creative power, which does not “mean” something but instead “does” something, transforming the very fabric of the body into a super-body with special powers. And like the *varṇas*, the powerful writing of DNA can be dismantled into its component pieces, atomically dispersed in the formation of new body-transfiguring effects. Similarly, the terminator body is also a body made powerful by a kind of writing, in this case, writing computer code, a fusing of body and language in order to effect a new and technically superior super-body, capable of fantastic feats. In this case, this writing on the body affords the terminator body an imperviousness to the usual frailty of the body, its susceptibility to death.

Thus the monism of science, which finds its apogee in a scientific reductionism that seeks to erase any traces of transcendent spirit, a spirit free from the body, inevitably leads us to a kind of language writing the body via the codes of DNA. The imaginary of this performative language is itself a kind of virtual body, DNA strands as a more subtle body writing of the external physical body, in a fusing of language as body with the physical.

